MCP

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The Ad Lib

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THE AD LIB: A DUO

(Author's Note: This was written with the express goal in mind to make everyone viewing this for the first time have no idea what is really going on. The more the performers can aid this dissonance, the better. What is real? What is scripted? Spoiler alert: It is ALL scripted. The guiding principle of this piece is: What is reality?)

CHARACTERS (with suggested doubling breakdown)

Alex - Performer 1
Jordan - Performer 2
Coach 1 - Performer 1
Coach 2 - Performer 2

** NOTE: Coach 1 and 2 are the same coach, just each does their own impression

(*Until the "BREAK" - which is noted - the start of the DUO should be performed in a manner that would make the viewer think it's not as well rehearsed as it could have been. This will make the break seem more realistic. The point is to constantly trick the audience into confusion. The guiding principle of this piece is: What is reality?)*

ALEX: Hello! And welcome to our performance of ALL of Christopher Marlowe's plays in under 10 minutes!

JORDAN: It's like the more popular compilations of Shakespeare's plays, but with a less well known playwright.

ALEX: So, if you don't know who Christopher Marlowe is - no worries!

JORDAN: Neither do we!

ALEX: (BREAK. This now needs to seem like a genuine argument and not the script. The goal is to make people uncomfortable.) Jordan, c'mon. How many times can you screw up the line?

JORDAN: What the what? We're performing, Alex.

ALEX: It's "Neither DID we" DID. DID. Not do. I swear to all that is holy, we have gone over this a hundred times. DID!

JORDAN: Who cares? What's the big deal? No one noticed. No one cares.

ALEX: It IS a big deal. "Do" means we currently don't know who Christopher Marlowe is, "DID" the CORRECT term, means that in the past we didn't know who he was but now we do, and are ready to teach THEM (points to audience).

JORDAN: This is why I didn't want to be paired with you.

ALEX: Oh, because I begged Coach to be paired with you? Right.

COACH 1: Now Alex, I know that Jordan is a terrible performer, but I need someone to step up, and you are clearly the most talented, the best really, performer on the team. Jordan won't be able to pull you down. Or dim your shine.

JORDAN: You are making everyone uncomfortable.

ALEX: (To an audience member) Are you uncomfortable? (To Jordan) No, I think they ALL understand my frustration.

JORDAN: They are smiling at you because everyone now knows who is getting the “6”. It’s us Alex. US. Because you have to nitpick every little thing.

ALEX: Not a little thing.

JORDAN: Let’s ask the judge. Did you even notice the tense I used?

ALEX: Don’t answer that! Jordan, you can’t address the judge in round, you are going to get us disqualified.

JORDAN: Who cares?! It’s not like we can start over, right?

(So, a judge might respond, or might not. This next bit should still work.)

ALEX: I’m sorry, you don’t need to respond, this is actually the DUO.

JORDAN: We are currently doing the script.

ALEX: It seems like we aren’t right now, because we are explaining we are doing the script.

JORDAN: But trust us, literally what I am saying right now is scripted.

ALEX: Like, I get that it seems as if we stopped doing the script to explain it to you, hence this isn’t scripted, but it is scripted. Every word.

JORDAN: I think this is level 3 right now, sort of like Inception. But I’ve never seen it. It’s just sort of part of the cultural knowledge now.

ALEX: You are too much, just stick to the script. It’s not hard.

JORDAN: I am literally doing the script word for word. You know this.

ALEX: So am I, Jordan, so am I.

JORDAN: So, why are you angry?

ALEX: It’s okay, we don’t really hate each other.

JORDAN: I mean, you smack your lips when you eat. You constantly show up late to rehearsal, and then leave early to “pick up your little brother”.

ALEX: I have a little brother.

JORDAN: Sure.

ALEX: Hold on, time out. Do you really hate me?

JORDAN: You are not my favorite person, no.

ALEX: Why did you agree to be my partner then?

JORDAN: Like I had a choice.

COACH 2: Now Jordan, you and Alex will be the perfect pair, you complement each other's strengths and weaknesses.

ALEX: Was that supposed to be Coach? I did it better.

COACH 2: Alex is pretty stuck up, between you and me. You will be a good influence. Since you are such a hard worker.

ALEX: I hate that I am standing up here with you.

JORDAN: This is literally page 3 only. (Deep breath). Okay. Let's see if we can save this thing. A shred of dignity. Can we try that?

ALEX: Yeah, fine.

JORDAN: Let's just do our introduction. Get back on track. Maybe we can nab the 5.

ALEX: (Pause, looking around the room.) Yeah, I think we can beat that team, even with this start. I am SO sorry, to have said that, I don't think that at all, it's just the script, I'm doing the script, I swear.

JORDAN: We really like your DUO.

ALEX: Did you cut out the insult so I look like the jerk?

JORDAN: What?

ALEX: The script had us both insulting a random DUO.

JORDAN: I must have had a different cutting than you did.

ALEX: I truly hate you now.

JORDAN: Introduction time?

ALEX: Fine.

INSERT INTRODUCTION

JORDAN: Ok, we are just going to start from the beginning, and we are just going to hope that the rest of this is so good, the judge will forget about how you (ALEX glares) we messed up earlier.

ALEX: That combined with that team totally messing up. I am so sorry, this is literally the script, I don't want to say this, you look like wonderful people, seriously find me in the cafeteria after this, I will show the script. (To JORDAN) But they'll probably mess up.

JORDAN: That's so mean.

ALEX: I know it's mean, Jordan. But it's in the script. Let's just get started. Ok?

JORDAN: Ok. You know what Coach always says:

COACH 2: Failures don't define you, you define you by how you get up again and move forward towards triumph.

ALEX: That's a terrible coach impression.

COACH 1: Failures don't define you, you define you by how you get up again and move forward towards triumph.

JORDAN: We are running out of time, I want to get through as much Marlowe as possible.

ALEX: Hello! And welcome to our performance of ALL of Christopher Marlowe's plays in under 10 minutes!

JORDAN: It's like the more popular compilations of Shakespeare's plays, but with a less well known playwright.

ALEX: So, if you don't know who Christopher Marlowe is - no worries!

JORDAN: Neither do we!

ALEX: Are you serious right now? Did you do that on purpose?

JORDAN: Do what?

ALEX: You said "do" instead of "did".

JORDAN: I am doing what the script says, Alex.

ALEX: You aren't though. I know what the script says, Jordan.

JORDAN: But I am doing the script exactly. As you are. You were supposed to say that.

ALEX: Who believes anything anymore?

JORDAN: The judge will trust me, right judge?

ALEX: Jordan, no one has the script. Look at your hands. Is there a script there? This is a memorized duo. No script.

JORDAN: I thought the judges had a copy of the script?

ALEX: At NATIONALS they do Jordan. Look around. Do you think we are at Nationals?

JORDAN: Well..

ALEX: Based on our performance so far, do you think we made it to Nationals?

JORDAN: I worked hard though.

ALEX: You did?

JORDAN: You don't take it very seriously, to be honest.

ALEX: How am I not taking it seriously? I'm the one making sure you say the right word!

JORDAN: (To audience) I'm saying it correctly. Just trust me. I practice in front of the mirror like twice a week.

ALEX: All we have done is lie to them this entire time.

JORDAN: The script is full of lies, true. But, the script itself is real.

ALEX: So, we are telling the truth about the lies?

JORDAN: Exactly. They (references audience) get it.

ALEX: You know what? This is like that time in third grade when the teacher gave us that test that said read all the directions thoroughly before starting the test and then the last question was "don't do the test".

JORDAN: I aced that.

ALEX: It was supposed to teach us the nuances of language, but all it taught us was not to trust the teacher who was trying to trick us.

JORDAN: I learned about nuance.

ALEX: You think “did” and “do” connote the same thing!

JORDAN: No one cares.

ALEX: I care!

JORDAN: Wait.

ALEX: What?

JORDAN: Is this the multiverse?

ALEX: How is this the multiverse? There is one of you and one of me.

JORDAN: So this is more of a simulation, where you and I are not saying what we want to say, but what the script says we are supposed to say?

ALEX: So, we have no free will? It’s just an illusion.

JORDAN: Let’s try. Say any word that comes to mind.

ALEX: Sparrow.

JORDAN: No, that was what the script told you to say.

ALEX: But they didn’t know that.

JORDAN: But we did. Say something crazy.

ALEX: I like how orange markers taste.

JORDAN: Drat. Dangit. Smelly. Shut the door. Refrigerator. Fork. Smurf.

ALEX: What are you doing?

JORDAN: Trying to curse. But I can just say the script.

ALEX: Wait, are you saying we aren't choosing to the do the script now? That the script controls us?

JORDAN: I think so.

ALEX: This is scary. Truce?

JORDAN: Truce!

ALEX: How do we get out of this?

JORDAN: What if we have to do something else we don't want to do?

ALEX: Like be mean to them? (Gestures towards DUO team)

JORDAN: What if it's worse?!

ALEX: Let's just stop and take a breath and go get lunch. Maybe we just need food.

JORDAN: Good idea. What's for lunch?

ALEX: I assume pizza.

JORDAN: It's not always pizza.

ALEX: It's almost always pizza.

JORDAN: I went to a tournament once where they had a taco bar.

ALEX: Oh wow. How was that?

JORDAN: It was fine.

ALEX: Oh. Was that a real memory of yours, or was it just from the script?

JORDAN: I honestly don't know any longer. I feel like it happened to me, but it was also in the script. But then again, I am also an actor playing a character written by someone else.

ALEX: So, we pretty much have three levels going on at all times.

JORDAN: It was someone's memory.

ALEX: Or made up.

JORDAN: Wow, the writer really hit a wall here, huh?

ALEX: I think this is right before lunch for him, too.

JORDAN: Do you think he eats pizza to stay in the moment?

ALEX: I think this is getting way too meta for me.

JORDAN: Let's just Ad Lib the rest of this. Remember in the script at that one point it just says "Ad Lib"?

ALEX: So, we just Ad Lib the remaining time?

JORDAN: Sure, is there a rule how long an Ad Lib could be?

ALEX: Great question.

JORDAN: What if there as a published script that just said "Ad Lib"?

ALEX: Jordan.

JORDAN: Alex.

ALEX: THIS script is CALLED Ad Lib.

JORDAN: Damn. Wait. I cursed. Are we ad libbing now?

ALEX: Damn. I cursed, too! We must be ad libbing! (To DUO team) Genuinely I am sorry. I will buy you a bag of chips or something.

JORDAN: Wait. is your character who only exists in this room offering to buy chips, or are you the actor offering to buy chips?

ALEX: I don't know.

JORDAN: I think we aren't totally ad libbing here then.

ALEX: I am. I think.

JORDAN: Part of the reason we don't know is they don't have a script, so they don't know either. This could be the script.

ALEX: Or it could be us just doing like duo impromptu hoping to get out of this situation and avoiding further embarrassment.

JORDAN: Good point.

ALEX: But we aren't. Judge, we get it, you have to go to tab, because you don't know what to believe.

JORDAN: You can believe us. Look at this face (references self). Not that one (references Alex). This one (references self).

ALEX: (At same time as Jordan.) Aaaaand scene.

JORDAN: (At same time as Alex). Aaaaaand scene.

ALEX: That was pretty good, huh?

JORDAN: So, the playwright, brilliant, brilliant man, basically read all of Christopher Marlowe's plays, distilled them into their essences, and wrote this as a modern adaptation of all of his plays.

ALEX: If you are a Christopher Marlowe scholar….

JORDAN: Said no one ever….

ALEX: Then you probably recognized the literal hundreds of clever references.

JORDAN: If you are not a Christopher Marlowe scholar…

ALEX: Said everyone….

JORDAN: Then you were probably just super confused.

ALEX: And in your case (references DUO), sorta mad. And upset.

JORDAN: Or even this explanation is all a big lie.

ALEX: What's the reality?

JORDAN: You choose.

ALEX: Or just do what the script says.

END